

GLOSSARY

Acute When symptoms come on rapidly; acute pain generally lasts for less than 3–6 months.

Alignment In yoga, the way a pose is instructed with the intention of encouraging optimal function and preventing injury; although there are general principles, proper alignment may vary from person to person and day to day, and based on the intention behind the pose.

Anatomy Study of the structure of the body, including the naming of parts.

Antigen Invader that the body's immune system fights with antibodies and white blood cells.

Arthritis Group of joint conditions that involves joint inflammation and/or damage; osteoarthritis is the most common type and involves damage to the cartilage of the joint due to wear and tear.

Asana Yoga pose or posture.

Bile Substance that helps break down fats in digestion.

Cartilage Firm but flexible connective tissue; includes hyaline (glasslike, in synovial joints to reduce friction), fibrocartilage (firm cushioning, in intervertebral disks for cushioning), and elastic (stretchy, in nose and ears for elasticity).

Central nervous system (CNS) The brain and spinal cord; controls the body and perceives the world.

Cerebral cortex Outer shell of the cerebrum.

Cerebrum Largest part of the brain; contains the cerebral cortex and some internal structures such as the hippocampus.

Cervical spine Seven vertebrae of the neck.

Chromosomes Threadlike molecules made of DNA and proteins; humans generally have 23 pairs.

Chronic Long-lasting symptoms, disease, and/or pain; chronic pain generally persists for longer than 3–6 months.

Collagen Key component in many connective tissues; has good tensile strength, allowing it to resist tension or pull.

Concentric contraction Muscle shortening in response to a load, as in lifting a weight in a biceps curl.

Connective tissue Forms connections in your body; subtypes include cartilage, bone, blood, lymph, adipose (fat), and elastic tissue (such as in the ears and nose), along with fibrous connective tissue.

Control group The research group that doesn't receive the intervention being studied; may receive nothing, or an active control, to act as a comparison.

Deep Further inward from the surface; for instance, your muscles are deep to your skin.

Diaphragm Usually refers to the respiratory diaphragm, which is the primary muscle used in a relaxed breath; there are also the vocal/thoracic outlet diaphragm and urogenital/pelvic floor diaphragm.

DNA Deoxyribonucleic acid; carries hereditary information in genes; within chromosomes.

Eccentric contraction Muscle lengthening in response to a load, as in lowering a weight in a biceps curl.

Engaging When a muscle is contracting; "Engaging while stretching" is used in this book to describe contraction while a muscle is in a neutral or lengthening position, as in an eccentric contraction, but held steady.

Epithelial tissue Forms coverings in your body, such as the superficial layer of skin.

Fascia Fibrous connective tissue that surrounds muscles and other organs.

Fibrous connective tissue Contains either a parallel or irregular pattern of collagen fibers; includes dense regular connective tissue, of tendons and ligaments, and dense irregular connective tissue, of fascia and synovial joint capsules.

fMRI Functional magnetic resonance imaging; machine that measures blood flow in the brain to reflect neural activity.

Gray matter Tissue in the central nervous system that contains mostly cell bodies, dendrites, and synapses (as compared to white matter which contains mostly axons and is white due to myelin).

Heart rate variability (HRV) Measure of the variation between heart beats within a specific increment of time; may be an indicator of cardiorespiratory and stress resilience.

Hip points Colloquial name for the two bony protrusions on the front of the pelvis, called the anterior superior iliac spines.

Homeostasis State of dynamic equilibrium maintained in the human body to support life.

Hot yoga Yoga classes in rooms heated to 92–105°F (33–40.5°C).

Hyperextension Extreme extension of a joint, often past normal range.

Hypermobility Extremely flexible beyond normal limits.

Hypertension High blood pressure.

Inflammation Indication that the body is fighting something locally or systemically; symptoms can include redness, swelling, heat, and pain.

Interoception Sensory body awareness of your internal environment, including of the digestive organs, heart, and muscles.

Intervertebral disk Disks, made mostly of fibrocartilage, which absorb shock between vertebrae and allow movement.

Inversion Poses, like Headstand, where the body is "upside down;" partial inversions include any pose where the head is below the heart.

Isometric contraction Muscle engagement where the muscle stays the same length, such as pushing into a wall or the floor.